The Monologue

By Marla Bentz

INTRODUCTION

Sometimes, when you get a girl talking, it's difficult to get her to stop. I mean, it's like riding a bike downhill with no brakes. Especially if it's one of those back pedal brakes…you know, those were always easier for me than the handle ones. I think it's something to do with my hand-eye coordination. That sounds like something a gym teacher would say. But I never really liked my gym teacher much, she was always sweaty and loud and- "The Monologue" by Marla Bentz

SARAH: Hi, I'm Sarah Walker. Why did I say that? You know that already. This is the first time I've ever auditioned. Professionally, I mean. For an actual role. School plays, church, things like that, I auditioned, but never - I'm sorry, I already said that.

You want me to tell you about myself. God, I don't know what to tell you. I'm seventeen. I graduated from the School of Performing Arts last month - Oh, yeah, I guess I did audition professionally. I mean I was in the chorus of a musical. But that hardly counts, does it? Nearly everyone in my class was in the chorus of that musical. And it closed after one night. It closed after half a night. Everyone walked out. Right in the middle of a number. Like a trail of ants. They trickled right out. And there we were, singing and dancing and...

I was born...I mean, this might be interesting. I was born in Liechtenstein. There aren't many foreigners born in Liechtenstein. Not many *people* born in Liechtenstein. See, my parents were on this trip, and I was born early, and I was born in...

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I came home when I was a week old. To British Columbia. Maybe I should explain that. My dad was working in British Columbia. I mean I'm not Canadian. Not that there's anything wrong with being Canadian. I'm not a Liechtenstinian either. Is that the word? Liechtenstinian? Sorry, I'm babbling.

Mom said she thought I started performing the day I was born. She was just kidding, of course, but I can't remember when I didn't want to be an actress. Oh, God, I thought. It would be so wonderful. To be someone else, to be anyone else, to be a lot of other - I didn't want to be me. Never wanted...

So, anyhow, I was always singing and dancing and reciting nursery rhymes. My mom says I knew the whole "Night Before Christmas" when I was a year and a half. A year and a half old, can you imagine? I'd say it at the drop of a pin. That's not right. Drop of a hat. That's right; that's what it is. Isn't it?

So, anyhow, I started singing and reciting poems and things in school and church and family reunions - I was never nervous. You might think I'm nervous. But I was never nervous. High-strung like a thoroughbred. That's what Dad said. He didn't know anything about horses. Never even saw a race. That's what he told me.

You're letting me babble on here. *(Laughs nervously.)* So maybe I could recite something. How about it? What do you say? Can I recite something?

Nah, I better not. You want to hear about my life. Well, there's nothing important. I grew up in - Oh, yeah, I used to play the accordion. Squeeze

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box is what Grandma called it. *(Broadly pantomimes playing an accordion.)* Bagpipes. That's what I thought the accordion sounded like. Don't ask me why. Same principle, I guess. Air squeezed in and out to make the sound. Bagpipes are always so, I don't know so...so mournful. Like the cry of a lonely siren *(Caught up in the mood)* luring sailors to deep, vast graves in the sea.

(Snapping out of it) But you don't want to hear about bagpipes; you know about bagpipes. The whole world knows about bagpipes. Maybe not the whole world.

(Takes a deep breath and expels it.) Where was I? Oh, yeah, so I grew up in Jersey. Newark. Can you imagine growing up in Newark? I didn't really grow up in Newark. I moved here when I was thirteen. I mean when I found out about the School of Performing Arts, and that the kids there got to audition for shows. Professional shows. Wow, you know. Anyhow, I came to stay with my grandma. And I went home weekends, except when I was in a *(Exaggerated French accent) tragedie* ou *comedie* ou a *lettle chanson* ou *danse nombair. (Seriously)* I didn't really want to go home. It was so strange going home. Back into all that - back into everything - I mean like Mom never even said any-

I'm making a fool of myself up here. Isn't that what I'm doing? Making a fool of myself. Well, so what? You wanted to hear me talk; you wanted to hear me sing and act. Did you want to hear me sing?

I don't have any brothers and sisters. Mom says who could put up with another one like me? She was just kidding...I think. *(Laughs and points straight ahead.)* Of course, she was kidding. *(Seriously again)* Except I

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know she and Dad would have been much happier if - I didn't ask them to be born, did I? And then the way he - I mean, nobody deserves to be tr- *(Brightly)* Say, don't I get to read or something? Oh, yeah, the paper you handed me. *(She pantomimes looking at a sheet of typing paper.)* When I'm done telling you about myself, I'm supposed to read it, act it. But am I done telling you about myself? I mean, I'm done telling you about myself if you want me to be done telling you about myself. But, I can...Oh, well.

Yes, now. I see. It's on the paper here. You told me my audition piece was on the paper here. Nothing prepared, you said. A cold reading. Right here on the paper. OK, here we go. Here it is. *(Reading from the imaginary paper, almost to herself)* "To be or not to be..." Oh, sure, I know that. Everyone knows that. Doesn't everyone know that? *(Reciting in broad Shakespearean tones)* "To be or not to be, that is the question. Whether 'tis nobler in the mind to suffer the slings and arrows of outrageous for - " Hey! Wait a minute here. This is Hamlet. This is a boy. I mean, not a boy, but a man. A young man. Maybe not a boy; he is in college, I think. Isn't he? A college boy. Man. Isn't Hamlet in college somewhere? Sweden, Denmark, something like - Oh, yeah, of course, he's *from* Denmark. He's Danish. Danish? How do you get Danish out of Den - Lochtenstunian! Maybe that's what I'd be if we hadn't come home. To British Columbia. To Newark. To...Actually, I don't know why they brought me home. They never wanted - And so - anyhow, I was glad to live with Grandma. I had to get away. Oh, God.

Hey, wait! Whoa! Hold everything. The fine print. I see the fine print

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here. *(Quoting from the imaginary paper from which she'd been reading)* This company was founded for the purpose of expanding gender and ethnic roles.

(Puzzled) A Dane is ethnic? So what am I? Aren't I ethnic already? I mean besides the way I look. See the way I look. And you have me playing a Danish white boy? I mean, hey, like they used to say, get with it! Ooh, sorry, I didn't mean anything. Wow, if I say stuff like that - I mean, if I keep on saying stuff like that, I'm really going to blow it, aren't I?

So shall we try it again? "To be or not -" Expanding our views and our roles, is that it? You know I kind of admire that. No, really, I mean I do. I really admire that.

So, hey, should I try a little dance step? Why don't I try a little dance step? *(Doing a chorus line step)* One and a two and a one and a two and a - Remember Lawrence Welk? Oh, God, when I was a little kid, I used to sit in front of the TV set when reruns of the "Lawrence Welk Show" came on. I wanted so badto be one of those sisters, what were their names? You know, the sisters who sang and all that stuff on the "Lawrence Welk Show"? I envied them so much. And Patty Duke. Remember her as a little girl with her own TV show? And those old movies? Shirley Temple and Margaret O'Brien. I'd give anything if I could have had a life that was just a little bit like -

Sorry. I'm really sorry. Oh, wow, you've just got to know how important this is to me. It's really important. More important than food and sleeping and...well, you know, don't you? Sure, you know, it's like the most important thing in the whole wor - Not really the most important.

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Grandma - well both Grandmas. And Grandpa...

(Mock serious) I never knew my one grandpa. Now don't get the wrong idea. He didn't die or anything. He was one of those astronauts who went to the moon. The one you never heard about, the one they all kept quiet about. It was my grandpa. Went to the moon. A young man. And he liked the moon. And so he decided to live on the moon. *(Trying to keep from laughing)* No, really, my grandpa's alive. Both grandmas and grandpas. It's really my uncle who lives on the moon. *(Laughs.)*

My grandma was a singer. Mom's mom, and Grandpa played guitar. That's how they met. Isn't that romantic? Now isn't it? And it's the truth. My other grandma plays the piano. Grandpa isn't musical though. He collects stamps.

So where was I? Oh, sure. A one and a - Nah! You don't want to see me dance. You want me to recite something? What? What can I recite? I know. *(Very hammy)*

"It was many and many a year ago In a kingdom by the sea. There lived a maid whom you may know By the name of...Sara Lee?"

Funny. *(Almost pleading)* Isn't that funny? You see, that's my name. Sarah Lee, with an "H." Sarah Lee Walker. *(Parody of a western movie)* So, what do you think about that, pardner?

(Her normal voice) Are you just going to let me die up here? I don't mean really die. I mean die like in doing a terrible job, not knowing what to say or do. Or

I got an idea. I'll tell you about my hobbies. *(Long pause)* I don't have any hobbies. The only thing I'm interested in is being an actress. That's my

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whole life's ambition. Everything else revolves around that. I'm being serious. I mean it. I know I've been kidding a lot, because, believe it or not, I didn't know what else to do. What else to say. But not now.

Why do people want to be actors or actresses? Why do I want to be an actress? I don't really know. It's just the most wonderful feeling in the world. Everybody watching and listening and the house so still you can hear a hat drop. *(Laughs and points.)* Got you again, didn't I?

(Seriously) No, but I mean it. It's not like I want to control people, or even that I feel I'm so important or special. *(Pause)* Even though I am. Important and special, I mean. Kidding. Just kidding.

(Seriously again) It's like I'm this instrument playing a duet with...God maybe? Or the consciousness of the universe. And everything's aligned somehow. And I'm the chemical catalyst or the reed of a tenor sax or the sounding board of a piano. And if I've rehearsed and studied and am confident, well, it's like I'm playing and being played so the audience hears one pure, sweet note. Or a resounding chord. *(Changing abruptly)* So you heard any good jokes lately? You'd think with my wanting to perform and loving to be up here on-stage that I'd be pretty good at telling jokes. Well, I'm not. I always mess up the punch line. I forget it or something. I wonder why. I can say lines in a play just fine. Right intonation and emphasis. But I can't tell a joke. Maybe life itself's a joke. And we're stuck with one role. I was stuck in one role. A role I hated, till I moved in with Grandma and Grandpa. Can a person be an actress just because her life is - because she

wants to get away, to escape - God, I'm seventeen years old. Why did I

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want to escape? Why do I still want...to...escape. *(Tears in her eyes)* It was like Mom didn't care. She knew what was going on. What Dad was doing to me. But she just didn't

(An abrupt change) So, hey, do I have the role or don't I? I mean, I feel like I've been up here forever, and I haven't said a blessed thing. Haven't done a blessed thing. I mean I was always good at ad-libbing. When I was in junior high, before I went to the school of performing arts, I joined the speech club. You know, readings and contests and stuff. Well, I always did well with the impromptu event. Give me a subject, and whether I know anything or not about it, I can talk. I'll show you.

Give me anything to talk about, any subject. Say it's... quantum physics. All right? Ahem. Ahem. Good evening, ladies and gentlemen.

Quantum physics, huh? What made me think of quantum physics? I don't know what made me think of quantum physics. Black holes. That's it. Quantum physics and black holes.

(Orotund tones) Ladies and gentlemen, a discourse on black holes. What is a black hole, ladies and gentlemen? It's a hole in the sky. A hole in the sky that's black. Not brown, not green, not red. But black. Yes, people, it's black. And why is it black? Well, because...it isn't really there. It's somewhere else. It's in some other universe. Ha! Didn't think I knew that, did you? A tunnel to the future or the past. Anti-matter. But you can't go through a black hole. If you tried to go through a black hole, it's hard to tell what would happen besides being crunched down so you'd cover only one billionth of a billionth of a pinhole... So thank you, ladies and gentlemen. My mother thanks you; my father thanks you; my

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grandmother thanks you; my grandfather thanks you. *(Her voice trails off.)* All of them... *(Sadly)* That's dumb. Mom and Dad wouldn't thank...they wouldn't care. But the big thing is that I'll be on my own, and Dad can't - *(Realizing what she's saying)* What am I saying?! But if I can play at being someone else, at least for a while, I really can be that person, become that person, do you see? Everything's better. Everything's different. I'm different. And Dad can't do those horrible things anymore, and Mom can't pretend she doesn't know what - *(Panicky)* Oh, my God, I'm sorry. I shouldn't say things like - I'm...sorry. *(Brightly)* SO...what else would you like to know? *(Pauses as if listening to a response.)* I can quit! I really can quit now. And I have the job. Oh, wow, I'll have to tell Grandma and Grandpa. And I'll tell Mo- *(Suddenly, she becomes dignified and composed, a young woman in command of her life.)* Thank you. Thank you very much. *(She nods and hurries Off-stage.)*

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier- Dramatic Interpretation
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